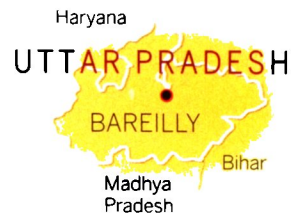


Operation Theatre

Smitten with theatre, a local doctor and his colleagues transform their passion into an exciting new world of entertainment for this sleepy town of seven lakh people



MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

**DR BRAJESHWAR SINGH
(CENTRE) WITH A
THEATRE TROUPE**

By Sheekesh Mishra

It's two in the morning and orthopaedic surgeon Dr Brajeshwar Singh and some of his colleagues get into an animated discussion about a play they saw the previous night. Nothing unusual except that these doctors at the Bareilly City Hospital are also preparing for a surgery they have to conduct in a few minutes. It is a routine they will follow at noon as well—making arrangements for organising another play between checking up patients and conducting surgeries. The ease with which they switch from one role to the other is striking. Though they are busy with their practice, it doesn't come in the way of their efforts to revive theatre in Bareilly—where seven lakh people have to make do with eight-odd old-style cinemas for entertainment.

It started 20 years ago, when Singh, a medical student at KGMC Lucknow, was fascinated by the play *Charandas Chor* at a city auditorium. Exposed to a new form of entertainment, his inclination for theatre became stronger with a trip to Prithvi Theatre in Mumbai when he watched a play called *Sandhya Chhaya*. The turning point however came four years ago when he

convinced his colleagues to accompany him for a play *Janeman* at the National School of Drama in Delhi. They were so taken in by the performance that he decided to make theatre more accessible in his own city.

His efforts paid off with Bareilly hosting its third annual theatre festival this January, where more than 700 people vied for 400 seats just to see Makrand Deshpande's *Sa Hi Besura*. The response to plays by Habib Tanvir, Usha Ganguly and K.S. Rajendran was equally encouraging and more than 3,000 people witnessed eight plays over six days. "I want to make Bareilly a cultural city like Pune," says Singh. Not an easy task due to the high costs of bringing in theatre groups. With success in getting local sponsors, Singh is confident that shows can be ticketed from next year. The popularisation of theatre in Bareilly has impressed many. Says Kashinath Sharma, the grandson of playwright Radheshyam Kathavachak: "This man is creating ripples in the minds of Bareillywallas." Renowned Urdu poet Waseem Bareillawi too agrees. "This is a welcome change." A change, he hopes, will spread to other parts of the state. ■